

Also Remember...

- Memory upgrades are available in the form of a Compact Flash card, Smart Media or Sony's memory stick. Some cameras don't allow upgrading, which is a severe limitation.
- Optical zooming is all that counts; Don't take the electronic zoom function too seriously.
- Floppies for storage aren't a great idea because they tend to be very unreliable, not to mention the limited capacity.
- Look for features such as printing directly from the camera through a special cable, taking sepia photographs, setting the shutter speed, selecting macro modes, auto focus, etc. Some cameras even let you capture short video clips.

Trigger Happy

As little as two years ago, anyone buying a digital camera would have had to put down as much as Rs 50,000 for a VGA camera with just 2 or 4 MB of storage space. These early models were very inefficient in power usage. Other features such as zooming, which are common in regular cameras, were also missing. However, in the current market, most mainstream cameras give you mega-pixel resolution (more than 1 million pixels), better battery life and even optical zoom lenses, all for as little as Rs 10,000 to Rs 15,000.

Technology Insight

Digital cameras use either a CCD or CMOS sensor, which captures light and converts it into an electrical charge to capture an image. CCD sensors lead to higher quality images. The size of a CCD sensor is approximately 4.4 mm x 6.6 mm as against the 24 mm x 36 mm size of the regular film.

Jargon Buster

Resolution: This is often expressed in megapixels. For example, 2.1 megapixels cor-



responds to about 1,600 pixels x 1,200 pixels.

Memory: Since cameras come with limited built-in memory (between 8 to 16 MB), this becomes a limitation when you are taking photos at higher resolution settings. At a resolution of 1,600 x 1,200, you'd be able to store just a few images in the TIFF format.

Interface: Connection to the computer is through USB or parallel port. The USB interface is preferable due to greater convenience and higher data rates.

Power: You will need a set of rechargeable batteries because the consumption tends to be high, especially when you are using the LCD viewfinder. Some manufacturers ship their cameras with power adapters, which is pretty useful when you are shooting indoors.

Separate monochrome display: It makes sense to have a separate monochrome display for camera status when you are trying to conserve battery life by switching off the LCD screen.

Viewfinder: Some cameras have a regular viewfinder in addition to the small LCD screen that also serves the purpose of power saving.



Decision Maker

	Casual user	Photography enthusiast	Professional
You need	To be able to take photos to compile personal albums or publish to the Web	High-quality images with plenty of configurability	Very high quality photographs with all the knobs and switches, plus expandability
Look for	Between 640 x 480 and 1,024 x 768 resolution and 2 MB memory; maybe one that doubles as a Web cam	1,280 x 1,024 resolution with at least 2X optical zoom and 8 MB storage	2,048 x 2,048 or higher with special lens options and a minimum 16 MB memory
Our pick	Logitech Click Smart 510	Fuji FinePix 2,800 Zoom, Nikon COOLPIX 775	Olympus C-5050ZOOM
Price range	Around Rs 10,000	Up to Rs 30,000	Up to Rs 60,000